exploration of the tension between the life of activity in the world (*pravritti-dharma*) and the renunciation of society and organised religion (*nivritti-dharma*). The *Gita* was probably put together gradually in the two centuries before the Christian era. Within mainstream Hinduism, the *Gita* is classified as ***smriti*** (traditional teaching) that clarifies and supports the *Vedic* revelation. It is one of the basic authorities for ***Vedanta***, and was the subject of commentaries by ***Shankara***, ***Ramanuja***, ***Madhva*** and their followers. Its synthesis of different paths (action, understanding and devotion to God) to salvation has opened it to many different interpretations.

A war is about to begin. *Arjuna* is in a chariot that is driven by the god *Krishna*. *Arjuna* is suddenly overcome by a crisis of conscience. How can he kill his relations and destroy the eternal laws of the family? He refuses to fight. *Krishna* tells him that warfare is his natural duty (*svadharma*) and it is better to perform one's own duty badly than that of another well. Human beings are immortal in that they have an everlasting and unchanging soul (***atman***). *Krishna* reveals that he is the god *Vishnu*, the creator, preserver, and destroyer of the worlds. His periodic 'descents' (*avatara*) restore righteousness (***dharma***) when it is in a state of decline. *Arjuna*'s dilemma illustrates the tension in orthodox Hinduism between duty and individual conscience, between self-determination and obedience to the rules derived from the infallible ***Veda***. *Arjuna* is a member of the warrior caste (*varna*), one of whose natural duties and functions is warfare. We see the conflict between the values of non-violence (***ahimsa***) and what is ordained by the *Vedic* tradition. More generally, he represents those who renounce (***samnyasa***) their prescribed social and ritual duties and status in favour of a life of solitary homelessness, self-discipline and spiritual wisdom. Their goal is liberation (***moksha***) from rebirth, repetition,